Cogent Business & Management

ISSN: 2331-1975 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/oabm20

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To cite this article: Nada Jabbour Al Maalouf, Sibelle Freiha, Joanna Hanna , Layal Sfeir & Chadia Sawaya (2026) From discounts to decisions: the mediating role of brand image in price promotions during turbulent times, Cogent Business & Management, 13:1, 2644549, DOI: 10.1080/23311975.2026.2644549

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/23311975.2026.2644549

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Published online: 17 Mar 2026.

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COGENT BUSINESS & MANAGEMENT
2026, VOL. 13, NO. 1, 2644549
https://doi.org/10.1080/23311975.2026.2644549

MARKETING | RESEARCH ARTICLE

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From discounts to decisions: the mediating role of brand image in price promotions during turbulent times

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ABSTRACT

Amid prolonged economic instability, consumers often recalibrate their purchasing decisions based on both price sensitivity and brand perception. This study investigates how price promotions influence consumer buying behavior and brand image in Lebanon, a market marked by hyperinflation and financial uncertainty. Grounded in the price sensitivity and price perception literature, the study further explores the mediating role of brand image in this relationship. Using a structured questionnaire, data were collected from 344 Lebanese consumers and analyzed using SmartPLS 4 employing Partial Least Squares Structural Equation Modeling (PLS-SEM). The results reveal that price promotions are significantly associated with consumer purchase decisions and positively shape brand image. Notably, brand image serves as a key mediator, suggesting that symbolic brand value remains influential even in highly price-sensitive contexts. These findings advance research on price sensitivity and promotional effectiveness by highlighting dual-pathway logic, combining economic pragmatism with brand-driven identity reinforcement. The study offers actionable insights for marketers seeking to balance short-term sales activation with long-term brand equity preservation in economically distressed environments.

ARTICLE HISTORY
Received 31 December 2025
Revised 19 February 2026
Accepted 9 March 2026

KEYWORDS
Brand image; consumer behavior; price promotions; price sensitivity; price perception; economic crisis; Lebanon

SUBJECTS
Consumer Psychology; Business, Management and Accounting; Economics

Introduction

Price promotions, which take part in a wide spectrum of tactical marketing initiatives to amplify sales, are delineated in multiple forms, covering discounts or temporary price reductions for products. As such, the promotional marketing strategy has been coined with customer responsiveness (Hermiyenti & Wardi, 2018), price sensitivity (Ali & Anwar, 2021), brand equity (Ambolau et al., 2015; Safitri, 2018; Sallam, 2014), and brand distinctiveness (Ambolau et al., 2015; Walean & Pratama, 2024). Indeed, price promotions contribute to increasing sales and retaining consumers, yet price reductions render a less distinctive status for brands, which impairs and weakens these brands. Traditionally, pricing literature has noted that frequent price promotions, particularly direct discounts, may dilute brand image by signaling lower quality, reduced exclusivity, or brand desperation (Hizam, 2025; Martinez et al., 2011; Zoellner & Schaefers, 2015). This concern is especially salient for brands positioned around symbolic value, prestige, or status. However, such assumptions are largely grounded in economically stable environments. In crisis-driven contexts characterized by hyperinflation and severe purchasing power erosion, the meaning consumers attach to price promotions may fundamentally shift. Rather than interpreting discounts as quality-reducing signals, consumers may perceive them as acts of fairness, accessibility, and even solidarity. Under economic hardship, price promotions may signal that brands are responsive to consumer suffering, potentially reinforcing rather than weakening brand image. Research in crisis contexts has revealed a more nuanced understanding. For example, Theodoridou et al. (2019) found that Greek consumers facing an economic crisis recalibrated their priorities, favoring affordability over quality, with promotions perceived as an act of fairness. Similarly, Jabbour Al Maalouf et al. (2024) and Jabbour Al Maalouf et al. (2025)

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demonstrated that despite financial constraints, Lebanese consumers continue to value symbolic brand associations, suggesting that brand image remains a key factor in shaping purchasing decisions, even in the face of economic hardship. These insights support the need for this study, which explores how price promotions may operate as symbolic signals, reinforcing brand image rather than diminishing it in Lebanon's hyperinflationary context.

Along these lines, adopting price discounts to drive sales is a common practice, yet limited findings offer a better comprehension of how price discounts influence customers' perceptions towards the brand as well as their purchase decisions. Prior literature navigated a variety of features related to price markdowns, brand image, and consumer purchase decisions. In-depth, Sallam (2014) argues that word of mouth (WOM) mediates the association between brand love, swayed by brand image and brand identity, and consumers' purchasing decisions. Likewise, Permana et al. (2018) concluded that both brand awareness and brand image significantly influence consumer purchase decisions. In turn, Albari and Safitri (2018) reported that price (fair, fixed, and relative) and brand image positively influence consumer purchase decisions, through their investigation of the role of counterfeit products' price and consumer buying behavior. Ali and Anwar (2021) investigated the impact of pricing strategies on consumer behavior and determined that competitive pricing, price skimming, marketing share sites, blogs, and penetration pricing all favorably tailor consumer shopping intent. Conversely, empirical evidence on whether these promotions are correlated with long-term brand image and overall consumer buying behavior, and to what extent, is still scarce. Further, a few previous studies discussed the dynamics between price promotions, brand image, and consumer buying decisions in markets heightened by unstable economic conditions, such as the Lebanese ecosystem.

Lebanon has been suffering from long-standing fiscal and monetary mismanagement, which has triggered severe inflation, a deepening economic crisis, and a reduction in purchasing power, with price sensitivity becoming even more pronounced (Hassoun, 2024; Ibrahim et al., 2021). As a result, Lebanese consumers' responses against price reductions and promotions are likely to be influenced by limited prior brand loyalty; instead, it is most likely the short-term relief expected from these promotions, given the sense of economic relief that price promotions provide.

By examining consumer behavior in Lebanon and the ongoing financial uncertainty experienced, this study gives new insights into how economic instability shapes and defines purchasing decisions. The Lebanese economic crisis and the aggravated uncertainty faced by citizens present a unique context to explore the psychological and behavioral responses of consumers facing difficult financial circumstances (Elhajjar, 2023).

Thus, this research aims to provide evidence to fill the literature gap by analyzing the interactions between price promotions, brand image, and consumer buying behavior within the Lebanese market, which has unique economic, cultural, and social cues. A combination of factors has led to an increased sensitivity of consumers to price, including rising inflation, currency devaluation, and significantly decreasing purchasing power. Within this realm, Lebanon is currently going through hyperinflation and extreme economic turmoil. The capacity of the population to meet basic needs has been severely hindered as a result of these crises, which have impacted customers' sharing of feedback to marketing. It is worth noting that consumers in Lebanon place a high priority on the luxury and quality of brands and often equate certain brands with their status within society (Farah & Fawaz, 2016). Therefore, it is possible that price promotions can be harmful in terms of diminishing perceived value. By that, the objective of this study is threefold, as it aims to investigate how price promotions affect the brand image and customer purchasing decisions amid challenging times, along with positioning brand image as a mediator of the nexus between price promotions and consumer purchasing decisions.

In brief, despite extensive research on price sensitivity and promotional effectiveness, limited empirical attention has been devoted to examining whether the traditionally assumed negative impact of price promotions on brand image holds under extreme economic volatility. Existing studies predominantly investigate promotional effects in stable or moderately competitive markets, where brand dilution concerns are valid. However, little is known about whether economic crises alter the symbolic interpretation of price promotions. The Lebanese hyperinflationary context provides a critical boundary condition to test whether discounting strategies operate differently when consumers face prolonged financial strain. Accordingly, this study investigates whether price promotions in crisis environments function not merely

as transactional incentives, but as symbolic signals that may counterintuitively strengthen brand image. Hence, three pivotal research questions are postulated:

RQ1. What is the impact of price promotions on brand image amid challenging times?

RQ2. What is the impact of price promotions on customer purchasing decisions amid challenging times?

RQ3. Does brand image positively mediate the correlation between price promotions and customer buying decisions during difficult times?

This study makes three distinct contributions to the literature on consumer behavior and pricing. First, the study challenges the dominant assumption within the pricing and brand equity literature that price promotions, particularly discounts, inherently dilute brand image. By examining a hyperinflationary crisis context, the findings demonstrate that this dilution logic does not universally apply. Instead, price promotions may operate as signals of fairness and adaptive responsiveness, thereby reinforcing brand image under economic distress. Second, the study advances research on promotional effectiveness by identifying brand image as a key mediating mechanism linking price promotions to consumer purchasing decisions. While prior research has largely examined direct price–behavior relationships, this study shows that promotional effectiveness operates through a dual-path logic: immediate economic relief and symbolic brand reinforcement. Third, the study offers context-specific empirical evidence from a hyperinflationary, crisis-affected economy, using Lebanon as a contextual stress test rather than merely a descriptive setting. By examining consumer behavior under extreme economic volatility, the findings illuminate boundary conditions under which conventional assumptions about discounting, brand dilution, and consumer loyalty may not hold.

Literature review

Price promotions

Price perception is considered a crucial element for consumers when considering a product. It is defined by the perceived cost the customer is bearing for a perceived quality when purchasing a product (Suri & Monroe, 2003). According to Armstrong et al. (2014), price perception is assessed by some key indicators, such as whether the price is meeting the required quality, the price paid is giving added value, the price is affordable, and competitive with similar products in the market. Hence, when companies do price promotions or discounts, consumers usually show strong interest in making a purchase; therefore, price discounts are often considered a significant attractor to customers (Yulianto, 2024). Hermiyenti and Wardi (2018) highlight the effectiveness of direct price reductions, such as discounts, in increasing demand within price-sensitive marketplaces. The authors anticipate that these types of promotions help consumers overcome financial constraints and increase their likelihood of purchasing items that were previously out of reach. In the same perspective, Safitri (2018) entails the effects of combining multiple products into a single discounted package, such as value bundles. In addition, Nangoy and Tumbuan (2018) found that promotion is significantly linked to purchasing decisions. In a similar vein, Ramadhan et al. (2024) revealed that price promotion can be a significant indicator that customers rely on when making purchase decisions. This emphasizes the importance of promotions in the eyes of customers. This strategy not only increases sales but also raises the perceived value of the product, particularly in environments with limited economic resources (Albari & Safitri, 2018). As such, consumers who place a high value on practicability and cost-effectiveness are likely to be drawn to this promotional strategy. In turn, Permana et al. (2018) concluded that loyalty programs that offer members exclusive discounts encourage repeat purchases while also fostering a sense of exclusivity, which helps to preserve the premium image of the brand. Walean and Pratama (2024) exhibit how time restraints on discounts are an effective tactic to incite urgency in the consumer since this tactic breeds consumers' fear of missing out (FOMO) and motivates immediate purchases because it still aligns with their exclusive brand. Complex or vague pricing can lead to skepticism or promotional fatigue (Darke & Dahl, 2003). While price promotions remain a powerful tool, over-reliance may reduce their effectiveness over time. Winer and Neslin (2023) found that there is a decline in long-term responsiveness to price promotions, especially among loyal

customers or in oversaturated markets. This suggests the importance of balancing promotions with other value-adding strategies, such as personalization and customer experience.

In the context of an economic crisis, price promotions may take on a different significance. Theodoridou et al. (2019) explored how Greek consumers reacted to price promotions during an economic downturn, finding that consumers no longer viewed price reductions solely as a signal of low quality but as an act of fairness in response to financial hardship. This shifts the traditional view that price promotions weaken brand image. Likewise, Jabbour Al Maalouf et al. (2024) demonstrated that even when financial constraints dominate consumer decision-making, the symbolic value of brands continues to influence purchasing decisions. These findings highlight the need for further investigation into how price promotions may function not only as transactional incentives but also as signals that enhance brand image in crisis contexts, particularly in markets like Lebanon.

Brand image

In an increasingly competitive world, maintaining a good reputation and securing a market position are critical assets to preserve the long-term success of an organization. Brand image is highly dependent on the perceptions of customers, meaning how they feel they are treated. Customers' trust is perceived as strong capital for organizational image. According to Keller (1993), brand image is an important component of brand equity because it establishes trust among consumers and loyalty to the brand and builds a relationship that transcends a mere transaction. Building and maintaining a strong brand image is essential for effective brand management, as it hinders potential competitors from entering the market because they might perceive the established brand image as too difficult to overcome (Park et al., 1986). Therefore, a well-executed brand-building strategy that aligns with consumer values and needs can significantly enhance a company's reputation, increase customer retention, and drive sustainable growth (Saxena & Dhar, 2021). Against this backdrop, Bauer et al. (2008) support that product attributes, perceived benefits, and customer attributes collectively influence image formation. To gain a deep understanding of the concept of brand image, it is noteworthy to highlight several points. First, a brand image should be recognized with an identifiable and well-known design. Moreover, brand image serves as a promise to consistently deliver the expected level of quality. From the consideration phase to the post-purchase phase, customers experience added value that reinforces their loyalty to the brand. Additionally, brand image always reflects and mirrors self-image; hence, customers buy brands and products that align with their own values and image. Thus, brand image is seen as a trademark that differentiates a product from another brand based on quality, design, color, symbol, and name. It also fosters the connection between buyers and the brand, leading to greater customer satisfaction and evidently increased purchase intentions (Kamins & Marks, 1991).

Consumer purchase decisions

Consumer purchase decisions are shaped by a plethora of factors and choices made by customers based on their needs, which they wish to fulfill (Hanaysha, 2018). These decisions involve various aspects such as the desired brand, the quantity they seek to purchase, the budget, timing, and place of purchase, preferred model, and payment methods. At this stage, consumers are often influenced by marketers and advertising campaigns, which provide information about the product, and they can, in turn, impact consumers' evaluations. To gain a deep understanding of consumer purchasing behavior, marketing managers should comprehend the process of consumption. Hanaysha (2018) outlines various stages in the consumer decision process, which begins with problem recognition, identifying a need. The next phase involves information gathering, which is done through internal sources and/or external sources. Internal sources involve searching for information based on past experiences, while external sources rely on friends, family, online platforms, and packaging. Based on this information, consumers assess alternatives and choices and select the best option that satisfies their needs and desires. Various factors can influence purchasing decisions, including advertising (Martins et al., 2019), sales promotions (Akbar et al., 2020; Ben Said et al., 2019; Hanaysha, 2018; Helmi et al., 2022), brand image (Agmeka et al., 2019; Ramesh et al., 2019), price (Hanaysha, 2018), and service quality (Dapas et al., 2019; Irawan et al., 2018).

Consumer buying habits are formed based on a complex mix of cultural, psychological, and situational influences that coalesce to shape the assessments and behaviors of consumers in the marketplace. Subjective value, situational context, and social proof are all pivotal factors shaping consumer behavior (Sallam, 2014). The extent to which promotional tactics that reflect existing community standards or qualify as exclusive promotional methods work is enhanced (Walean & Pratama, 2024). Furthermore, Permana et al. (2018) have indicated that marketing methods aimed at a different culture that utilize social influences, such as communal or word-of-mouth acknowledgment and validation, bolster the success of promotional items. Moreover, Ambolau (2013) suggested promotional efforts rooted in engagement with the community to provide a greater impact of some practices, extending beyond a typical buy. By sharing social proof, community connection, and culturally based expectations, not only do merchants increase consumer awareness, but they also maintain brand equity in an ambiguous space and future to buy. Similarly, Prasad and Jha (2014) explored how various consumer decision-making models align with purchasing behaviors, noting that these behaviors are influenced by the urgency of needs and wants for specific products. According to the authors, product relevance plays a critical role in the decision-making process, with consumers considering factors such as utility, urgency, price, quality, individual attitudes, perceptions, and self-concept when making purchase decisions. This reflects a broader understanding that consumer behavior is multifaceted, and decisions are shaped by both practical considerations and psychological factors.

Theoretical background: price sensitivity and consumer evaluation under economic uncertainty

Consumer responses to price promotions have been extensively examined within the price sensitivity and price perception literature. Price sensitivity refers to the degree to which consumers adjust their purchasing behavior in response to price changes (Abdullah-Al-Mamun et al., 2014). In economically stable contexts, consumers may weigh price alongside brand loyalty, perceived quality, and symbolic value. However, in periods of economic distress, price considerations often become more salient due to heightened financial constraints and reduced purchasing power (Kumar et al., 2014).

Price sensitivity is not a unified grand theory but rather a well-established behavioral construct grounded in pricing and consumer evaluation research (Abdullah-Al-Mamun et al., 2014). It explains the degree to which consumers adjust their purchase behavior in response to perceived price changes and perceived sacrifice. In crisis-driven contexts, heightened financial constraints increase the salience of price cues, making price-based signals particularly influential in shaping consumer evaluations and behavioral intentions. Empirical evidence from crisis-affected economies further supports this behavioral shift. For instance, Theodoridou et al. (2019), examining Greek consumers during a prolonged economic crisis, found that reduced income levels significantly altered purchasing priorities, leading consumers to reject higher-priced quality options and prioritize affordability. Their findings demonstrate that economic crises reconfigure evaluative criteria, with objective financial constraints directly shaping attitudes and consumption patterns. This suggests that in adverse economic conditions, consumers recalibrate trade-offs between price and quality, potentially altering the symbolic interpretation of promotional signals.

Similarly, research conducted in economically challenged regions demonstrates that crisis conditions amplify the role of attitudinal mechanisms in shaping purchase intentions. Jabbour Al Maalouf et al. (2024) found that even under financial strain, consumer attitudes remained the strongest predictor of behavioral intention, outweighing structural constraints. Their findings suggest that symbolic and evaluative mechanisms continue to operate in distressed markets, reinforcing the importance of integrating attitudinal constructs when modeling consumer responses to economic stimuli.

The Lebanese economic crisis, characterized by hyperinflation and currency devaluation, provides a context in which consumers are likely to demonstrate elevated sensitivity to price changes. Under such conditions, temporary price promotions may serve not only as financial incentives but also as evaluative cues that shape perceptions of fairness, accessibility, and value. Research in price perception suggests that consumers rely on observable marketplace signals, such as discounts and promotional framing, to infer product quality and brand intentions, particularly when uncertainty is high.

Within this framework, price promotions can influence consumer decision-making through two complementary pathways. First, they provide immediate economic relief by reducing perceived financial sacrifice. Second, they shape brand-related inferences by signaling value responsiveness and market sensitivity. The extent to which these promotional cues translate into purchase decisions may depend on how they affect brand image. Brand image captures consumers' cumulative perceptions of quality, trust, and symbolic meaning (Keller, 1993), and therefore may function as a psychological mechanism linking price-based stimuli to behavioral outcomes. Drawing on customer-based brand equity theory (Keller, 1993), brand image represents accumulated brand associations that shape consumer evaluations beyond immediate price considerations.

Accordingly, this study advances research on price sensitivity and promotional effectiveness by integrating brand image as a mediating construct in crisis-driven consumption contexts. Rather than treating price effects as purely utilitarian, the proposed framework recognizes that even under economic strain, consumers interpret price promotions through brand-related lenses that influence their ultimate purchase decisions.

Research context

Marked by hyperinflation, major currency devaluation, and the loss of purchasing power, the present economic crisis in Lebanon has sparked a dramatic change in consumer behavior (Hassoun, 2024). With increased price sensitivity now a major behavioral characteristic, consumers have moved from discretionary spending to prioritizing necessities (Rohanaraj, 2023; Safitri, 2018). Lebanese customers often choose utilitarian products over branded or luxury ones as financial constraints grow, therefore compromising quality to reach affordability. Kaakour and Hassoun (2024) confirm that this change shows increasing pragmatism, whereby people prefer quick savings to long-term brand loyalty (Hassoun, 2024).

Furthermore, the sociopolitical turmoil that consumed Lebanon in 2024 has underlined the need for cultural cohesion and community-oriented values. In such a closely connected society, marketing plans, including price discounts, must not only provide quick financial relief but also maintain the symbolic value of the brand (Permana et al., 2018). Overly or careless discounting could unintentionally imply lower quality or brand desperation, therefore harming brand image in the eyes of culturally sensitive consumers (Ambolau, 2013; Sallam, 2014). Keller (1993) argues that maintaining a good brand image is pivotal for preserving consumer trust, particularly when using forceful pricing policies.

In this sense, the brand name acts as a cultural signifier, showing where one should buy and what decisions support social standing. Price discounts run the risk of turning off status-conscious customers if they are seen as compromising the premium positioning of a brand. So, to maintain trust and loyalty, marketers have to carefully weigh brand reputation against cost savings (Ali & Anwar, 2021). Fear of future price increases and product shortages, especially for necessary items like food, medications, and children's products, has led Lebanese consumers to participate in panic buying (Hassoun, 2024). This behavior emphasizes the need and psychological pressure behind present buying choices and the importance of carefully designed price promotions in addressing both financial and emotional consumer demands.

Hypotheses development

Price promotions and brand image

Following Wasik et al. (2023), both price perception and promotion are delineated as the most influential drivers in swaying consumers' minds and desire to purchase a product from a certain brand. As such, the authors argue that brand image plays a mediating role in the association between price perception, promotion, and customers' buying decisions since it is statistically correlated to the price variables and purchase decision-making as well. In the same perspective, Hermiyenti and Wardi (2018) concluded that promotion, price, and brand image all had a significant influence on purchasing decisions, with brand image serving as a key mediator in the relationship between the three factors. Effective marketing strategies that incorporate these components have the potential to enhance purchasing decisions. Along

these lines, prior observed insights underscore the causal linkage between price promotion and brand image, as promotions and discount offers are entailed as positive influencers on brand image, indicating that the better the promotions and the more frequent discounts a brand can offer, the more its image is enhanced (Afifah & Sakti, 2024). Conversely, Martinez et al. (2011) posit that the impact of promotions on brand image highly varies according to the dual effect of the type of promotional tool and product category. In turn, Zoellner and Schaefers (2015) distinguish between direct price reduction, which has the strongest positive impact on brand perception, versus indirect price reduction and marketers' pre-condition tool covering promotional offers of loyalty programs, trade-in incentives, or gifts, which exert lower effects on brand perception. Thus, building on price perception research and the findings of previous studies, the following hypothesis is presented:

***H_1**: Price promotions have a positive association with brand image amid challenging times.*

Price promotions and consumer purchasing decisions

Price promotions line of inquiry has been incorporated in consumer purchasing behavior research, with conceptualized features and different types of price promotions: Niu et al. (2024) consolidate that all three characteristics of price promotion, covering promotion depth, breadth, and duration, positively affect consumer buying behavior, with stratified degrees of significant influence. According to the authors, employing different promotion methods not only promotes purchasing promoted products but also prompts the buying of non-promotional items. In contrast, Ercan et al. (2025) posit that customers tend to prefer purchasing memberships over cash payment, as they prefer promotions that stretch their membership duration and perceive discounts as less beneficial under time pressure. Conversely, Zhao et al. (2021) intend that product pricing, along with product packaging, both exert a significant impact on the buyer decision process. In this backdrop, previous evidence suggests that promotion and price examined constructs collectively affect consumer purchase decisions, price being the most influential variable, whereas promotion is directly and indirectly positively correlated with consumer purchase decisions (Laoli et al., 2024; Supriadi et al., 2023). In-depth, Ambolau et al. (2015) give particular attention to fair price, fixed price, and relative price in their study of the influence of product price on the purchasing behavior of customers. As a result, the scholars' evidence shows that consumers utilize price as an important indicator of product quality and value, and it dictates customers' buying decisions. Likewise, Safitri (2018) concluded that both pricing (fair and fixed price) exerts a positive effect on the kind of decisions the consumers make concerning their purchases; whilst Ali and Anwar (2021) elucidate various pricing strategies, including competitive pricing, psychological pricing, price skimming, marketing sharing sites, and penetration pricing, which all significantly and favorably influence consumer buying behavior. Plus, based on recently emerged findings, promotional activities have a relatively minor direct impact on purchase decisions, which is amplified when mediated by purchase interest (Walean & Pratama, 2024). Based on those insights, a new hypothesis is added to the contingent framework as follows:

***H_2**: Price promotions have a positive association with consumer purchasing decisions amid challenging times*

Brand image and consumer purchasing decisions

Many prior studies have outlined the nexus between price perceptions, brand image, and consumer purchase behavior, as authors evoke the mediating role of brand image in such associations. Waworuntu and Hasan (2021) and Ningsih and Pradanawati (2021) pinpoint that brand image, price perception, and price promotion all positively and significantly influence product purchasing decisions. In parallel, Angeline et al. (2023) argue that brand image fully mediates the causal linkage between promotional strategies, encompassing price promotions and purchase decisions, suggesting that a favorable brand image sways customers' perceptions of promotions made to amplify sales and purchase decisions. In the same perspective, Adirinekso et al. (2021) consolidate that brand image is captured as a partial mediator for the sales promotion influence on buying decisions and a

complete mediator of price variables' effect on purchasing decisions as well. Similarly, Wasik et al. (2023) intend that brand image plays a mediating role in the correlations between price perceptions, promotions, and purchasing decisions. Crisis-sensitive consumer research in Lebanon further reinforces the centrality of attitudinal mediation mechanisms. Jabbour Al Maalouf et al. (2025) demonstrated that attitudes serve as a pivotal mediator linking motivational drivers to online food ordering intentions during periods of socio-economic instability. Their findings suggest that even when consumers are driven by functional motivations such as convenience and perceived value, attitudinal constructs remain the key transmission mechanism translating stimuli into behavioral intention. This supports the proposition that brand image may operate as a similar mediating mechanism in the context of price promotions during economic turbulence. Consequently, in line with these previous observations, a third hypothesis is stipulated:

***H_3**: Brand image mediates the association between price promotions and customer buying decisions amid challenging times.*

Methodology

Research design

The investigation conveys a positivist philosophy and a deductive approach with a mono-quantitative methodological choice. Given the absence of a comprehensive consumer sampling frame in Lebanon due to ongoing economic disruption, an online survey approach was deemed appropriate to capture active consumers exposed to price promotions. A cross-sectional survey was circulated via online networks. The survey was split into four sections. The first section covered demographic information. The second one reflected the brand image (BI) examined based on perceived quality, brand loyalty, and overall brand image, which are presumably critical factors influencing consumer behavior. The three statements were adapted from Moenardy and Ximenes (2023). The third section includes four statements related to price promotions (PP) adapted from Hustic and Gregurec (2015). Lastly, the fifth section is reserved for respondents' consumer buying decisions (BD) using five statements adopted from the study of Rohanaraj (2023) on consumers' reactions to promotions, encompassing purchase frequency, likelihood of repeat purchases, and price sensitivity, and cover five statements.

Although the measurement items used in this study were adapted from previously validated scales, to ensure contextual relevance, each item was reviewed by five marketing and consumer behavior experts familiar with the Lebanese market. Adjustments were made to account for cultural appropriateness, economic sensitivity, and linguistic clarity. A pilot test (n = 20) of Lebanese consumers was conducted to assess comprehensibility and relevance. Feedback confirmed that the adapted instruments effectively captured consumer attitudes and behaviors within Lebanon's crisis-driven consumption environment.

The survey's participants were afforded substantial information regarding the research objective, data utilization, and their rights as research subjects. Participants of the questionnaire, hence, confirmed their informed voluntary consent for contributing to the survey, and ethical consideration was ensured upon server confidentiality. Also, the names of the survey's participants were not supplied to avoid privacy issues. Lastly, ethical approval was obtained from the Research Ethics Committee (REC) of the Higher Center for Research (HCR) at the Holy Spirit University of Kaslik (USEK) on 30 April 2025 under the reference HCR/EC 2025-043.

Population and sample

The focus of the research is Lebanese consumers aged 18 years or above, who actively purchase goods and services. This group has been selected on purpose, as this segment is directly involved in consumption and is an obvious participant in price-related marketing campaigns. This study utilizes non-probability convenience sampling to survey Lebanese consumers. Thus, an online survey was distributed via Google Forms from 30 April 2025 to 30 June 2025. A final data set of 344 participants was obtained.

Data analysis

Partial Least Squares Structural Equation Modeling (PLS-SEM) was employed to test the hypothesized relationships presented in the conceptual model. The analysis was conducted using SmartPLS 4, which is appropriate for prediction-oriented research, complex mediation models, and exploratory frameworks in emerging or crisis-driven contexts. PLS-SEM was selected due to its suitability for examining variance-based relationships and its robustness under non-normal data conditions. The analysis followed the two-step approach recommended for PLS-SEM. First, the measurement model was evaluated by assessing indicator reliability (outer loadings), internal consistency reliability (Cronbach's alpha and composite reliability), convergent validity (average variance extracted, AVE), and discriminant validity using the heterotrait–monotrait ratio (HTMT). Collinearity was examined using variance inflation factors (VIF). Second, the structural model was assessed by examining path coefficients, coefficients of determination (R^2), effect sizes (f^2), and predictive relevance (Q^2 predict). Statistical significance was determined using bootstrapping with 5,000 resamples. Mediation effects were evaluated through the significance of indirect effects and the calculation of variance accounted for (VAF).

Results

Sample profile

Table 1 presents the demographic characteristics of the respondents, including gender, age, education, marital status, and income distribution.

Measurement model assessment

Indicator reliability was assessed by examining the outer loadings of the reflective measurement model. Table 2 presents the standardized loadings for all measurement items. All indicator loadings exceeded the recommended threshold of 0.70, confirming satisfactory indicator reliability.

Internal consistency, reliability, and convergent validity were assessed using Cronbach's alpha, composite reliability, and AVE, as shown in Table 3. All constructs demonstrate satisfactory reliability, with Cronbach's alpha and composite reliability values exceeding 0.70. Furthermore, AVE values were above 0.50, confirming convergent validity.

Discriminant validity was evaluated using HTMT, presented in Table 4. All HTMT values were below the conservative threshold of 0.85, indicating that discriminant validity was established.

Table 5 presents the bivariate correlations among the latent constructs. All correlations are below the critical threshold of 0.85, indicating no multicollinearity concerns and supporting discriminant validity.

Collinearity was also assessed using VIF. All VIF values in Table 6 were below the conservative threshold of 5 or marginally at the acceptable boundary, indicating no critical multicollinearity concerns.

Table 1. Sample profile.

Category	Subcategory	Percentage (%)
Gender	Female	55.5
	Male	44.5
Age	between 18 and 25 years	54.3
	between 26 and 35 years	32.5
	between 36 and 45 years	10.1
	46 and above	3.1
Educational Background	High School	25.6
	BA Degree	60.5
	Master's Degree and Above	13.9
Marital Status	Single	64.3
	Married	35.7
Monthly Income	Below $ 800	22.4
	Between $ 800 and $ 2,000	69.5
	Higher than $ 2,000	7.9
	Prefer not to disclose	0.2

Table 2. Indicator loadings.

	Outer loadings
BD1 <- BD	0.854
BD2 <- BD	0.877
BD3 <- BD	0.900
BD4 <- BD	0.900
BD5 <- BD	0.893
BI1 <- BI	0.953
BI2 <- BI	0.909
BI3 <- BI	0.924
PP1 <- PP	0.891
PP2 <- PP	0.917
PP3 <- PP	0.874
PP4 <- PP	0.868

Table 3. Construct reliability and convergent validity.

	Cronbach's alpha	Composite reliability (rho_a)	Composite reliability (rho_c)	Average variance extracted (AVE)
BD	0.931	0.940	0.948	0.783
BI	0.920	0.920	0.950	0.863
PP	0.910	0.917	0.937	0.788

Table 4. Discriminant validity (HTMT criterion).

	Heterotrait-monotrait ratio (HTMT)
BI <-> BD	0.444
PP <-> BD	0.451
PP <-> BI	0.570

Table 5. Correlation matrix of latent constructs.

	BD	BI	PP
BD	1.000	0.414	0.427
BI	0.414	1.000	0.526
PP	0.427	0.526	1.000

Table 6. Collinearity assessment (outer VIF values).

	VIF
BD1	2.997
BD2	3.437
BD3	3.710
BD4	3.987
BD5	4.139
BI1	5.044
BI2	2.938
BI3	3.627
PP1	3.115
PP2	3.753
PP3	2.797
PP4	2.360

Table 7. Structural model results (direct effects).

	Original sample (O)	Sample mean (M)	Standard deviation (STDEV)	T statistics (|O/STDEV|)	*p* values
BI -> BD	0.262	0.259	0.069	3.798	0.000
PP -> BD	0.289	0.297	0.069	4.188	0.000
PP -> BI	0.526	0.529	0.050	10.509	0.000

Structural model assessment

The structural model was evaluated using bootstrapping with 5,000 resamples. The results of the hypothesis testing are presented in Table 7. All hypothesized direct relationships were statistically significant at $p < 0.001$.

Table 8. Coefficient of determination (R^2) and effect sizes (f^2).

Endogenous construct	R^2	R^2 adjusted	Predictor → outcome	f^2
BD	0.23	0.228	BI → BD	0.07
			PP → BD	0.08
BI	0.28	0.275	PP → BI	0.38

Table 9. Mediation analysis (specific indirect effect).

	Original sample (O)	Sample mean (M)	Standard deviation (STDEV)	T statistics (|O/STDEV|)	*p* values
PP -> BI -> BD	0.138	0.136	0.035	3.892	0.000

Table 10. Predictive performance assessment.

	Q^2 predict
BD	0.171
BI	0.268

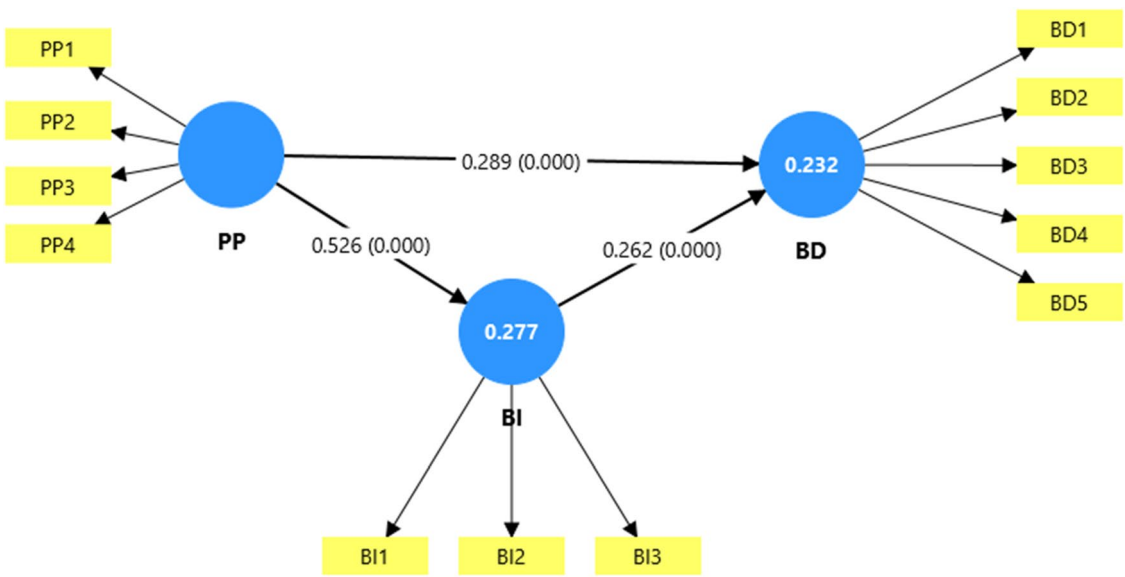

Figure 1. Structural model results.

The explanatory power of the structural model was assessed using the coefficient of determination (R^2), while effect sizes were evaluated using f^2 statistics. As shown in Table 8, the model explains 27.7% of the variance in BI and 23.2% of the variance in BD, indicating moderate explanatory power. The effect size of PP on BI was large (f^2 = 0.383), whereas the effects of PP and BI on BD were small.

The mediating role of BI in the relationship between PP and BD was assessed using bootstrapping. The indirect effect of PP on BD through BI was significant ($\beta = 0.138$, $p < 0.001$) (Table 9), and the direct effect remained significant, indicating partial mediation. The total effect of PP on BD was 0.427. The VAF was 32%, indicating that approximately 32% of the total effect of PP on BD is transmitted through BI, confirming partial mediation.

The model's out-of-sample predictive performance was evaluated using PLSpredict. Q^2 predict values for BI (0.268) and BD (0.171) were above zero (Table 10), indicating moderate predictive relevance. These indicate that the model demonstrates moderate out-of-sample predictive capability.

Figure 1 illustrates the final PLS-SEM model with standardized path coefficients and R^2 values for BI and BD. All displayed path coefficients are statistically significant at $p < 0.001$.

Discussion

At the onset, price promotions are significantly and positively associated with brand image ($\beta = 0.526$, $p < 0.001$), accepting H_1. This finding aligns with prior studies that highlight the role of promotions in

enhancing brand perceptions. For instance, research by Hermiyenti and Wardi (2018) and Wasik et al. (2023) corroborates that price promotions, particularly those involving direct discounts, are perceived as indicators of fairness and accessibility, reinforcing the brand's value even in economically uncertain contexts. This outcome refines rather than fully contradicts earlier dilution concerns that price promotions might erode brand equity (Zoellner & Schaefers, 2015). Instead, it suggests that consumers, especially in crisis-driven economies like Lebanon, view price promotions not as a devaluation of the brand, but as a response to economic necessity, while still preserving brand value. By highlighting that brand image benefits from promotions in an unstable economy, this study challenges the conventional notion that price discounts harm brand prestige (Martinez et al., 2011). The findings of this study contribute to a growing body of research exploring consumer behavior in crisis contexts. Previous studies, such as Theodoridou et al. (2019) and Jabbour Al Maalouf et al. (2024), have shown that economic crises alter the interpretation of price promotions, with consumers in financially distressed environments viewing promotions as a sign of fairness and accessibility, rather than a reduction in brand prestige. This study extends these findings by demonstrating that, in Lebanon's hyperinflationary context, price promotions enhance brand image, operating through both economic and symbolic pathways. The findings indicate that Lebanese consumers, in particular, respond positively to promotions, maintaining a connection to the symbolic value of the brand while perceiving economic relief. This result also complements Ali and Anwar (2021), who noted that effective pricing strategies can enhance consumer trust and loyalty, even in uncertain economic conditions.

Further, price promotions are also positively associated with consumer purchasing decisions ($\beta = 0.289$, $p < 0.001$), thereby supporting H2. This outcome aligns with several previous studies, such as Niu et al. (2024) and Walean and Pratama (2024), who found that price promotions directly stimulate consumer purchase behavior, especially when consumers are financially constrained. In a similar vein, Ambolau (2013) argued that price promotions act as a strong motivator for consumers, particularly in markets where price sensitivity is heightened due to economic instability. The findings extend this research by demonstrating that price promotions serve as an effective means to activate consumer purchases in Lebanon, a market facing hyperinflation and currency devaluation. While past studies like Safitri (2018) and Zhao et al. (2021) suggest that price alone can drive purchase decisions, this study further demonstrates that the Lebanese context, defined by severe economic distress, amplifies the effectiveness of such strategies.

In line with H3, this study reveals that brand image mediates the association between price promotions and consumer buying decisions ($\beta = 0.138$, $p < 0.001$). This finding suggests that while price promotions directly influence purchasing behavior, they also do so by enhancing brand image, which, in turn, drives purchase decisions. The total effect of price promotions on buying decisions through both direct and indirect (mediated by brand image) pathways was found to be 0.427. This indicates that brand image plays a substantial role in shaping how price promotions are perceived and, ultimately, how they affect consumer behavior. The concept of brand image as a mediator is supported by earlier research by Angeline et al. (2023) and Adirinekso et al. (2021), who found that brand image strengthens the effectiveness of price promotions. Similarly, Waworuntu and Hasan (2021) found that a favorable brand image enhances the impact of promotional strategies on consumer purchase decisions. This study adds to this literature by providing empirical evidence of this mediation in a crisis-ridden economy like Lebanon's. These findings are consistent with prior crisis-context studies conducted in Lebanon (Jabbour Al Maalouf et al., 2024, 2025), which similarly identified attitudinal constructs as central transmission mechanisms between external stimuli and behavioral intentions. Moreover, the partial mediation (VAF = 32%) suggests that while brand image is an important mediator, price promotions still exert a strong direct effect on consumer purchasing behavior, even without the full mediation of brand image. This finding suggests that price promotions in economically distressed environments operate through two key mechanisms: an immediate financial relief effect (direct effect) and a long-term symbolic reinforcement effect (mediated by brand image). This dual-pathway mechanism was not only noted by Wasik et al. (2023) but is also supported by this study's findings, which show that Lebanese consumers perceive promotions as both practical (financial relief) and symbolic (brand value enhancement).

This study offers several key contributions that advance the understanding of price promotions, brand image, and consumer purchasing decisions in economically challenging contexts. First, it challenges the

widely held assumption that price promotions necessarily harm brand image in economically turbulent environments. Unlike studies such as Zoellner and Schaefers (2015), which argued that price promotions might harm premium brand perception, the findings in Lebanon suggest that brand image can be enhanced through thoughtful promotional strategies that focus on accessibility without compromising perceived value. Second, by highlighting the mediating role of brand image, this research extends the work of Waworuntu and Hasan (2021) and Angeline et al. (2023), who emphasized the importance of brand image in strengthening the impact of price promotions. However, it goes further by demonstrating that this mediation is significant even under severe economic distress, where consumers are more focused on short-term price relief rather than long-term brand loyalty. Third, the findings of this study align with previous work on consumer behavior in crisis contexts (e.g. Hassoun, 2024; Rohanaraj, 2023), but they offer a novel insight by showing that Lebanese consumers in particular do not appear to interpret price promotions as undermining brand equity. Rather, they see promotions as essential tools for managing their purchasing power while maintaining a connection to brands that signal status and quality, even in uncertain times.

Theoretical implications

This study contributes to the advancement of research on price sensitivity and promotional effectiveness by empirically validating a mediation mechanism that integrates brand image into price-driven decision models. Traditional price sensitivity research often suggests that price-conscious consumers, particularly in distressed economies, prioritize affordability above other factors. However, the present findings indicate that brand image continues to play a meaningful role in shaping consumer behavior, even when financial considerations are dominant.

The mediation effect identified in this study suggests that consumers weigh not only price savings but also how such savings align with perceived quality, value, and symbolic meaning. In Lebanon's turbulent economy, consumer decision-making appears to operate through two complementary evaluative mechanisms: a utilitarian mechanism focused on financial sacrifice reduction and a symbolic mechanism rooted in brand meaning and identity reinforcement.

By demonstrating that price promotions can enhance brand image rather than erode it in crisis contexts, this study refines existing assumptions in pricing research and underscores the importance of integrating psychological and brand-related mechanisms into models of price-driven consumption under economic strain.

Managerial implications

The empirical results of this study offer marketers and brand strategists operating in volatile economies several actionable insights.

First, the significant association between price promotions and consumer purchasing decisions suggests that time-limited and need-based promotions are effective in driving short-term purchases. Especially in hyperinflationary environments like Lebanon, where purchasing power is diminished, consumers respond positively to financial relief that aligns with necessity-based consumption.

Second, the observed positive association between price promotions and brand image indicates that promotional strategies, when perceived as value-adding rather than desperate, can actually enhance brand perception. Therefore, brands should avoid generic discounting and instead use targeted strategies such as bundled value offers or promotions tied to loyalty programs. These tools can create a sense of exclusivity and preserve brand identity in culturally status-conscious markets.

Third, the mediating role of brand image implies that promotions are not only functional but also symbolic. Brands should frame promotions in emotionally resonant ways, for example, by linking them to community values or national resilience, to reinforce consumer-brand trust. This is particularly important in Lebanon, where consumers often associate brands with social status and emotional connection.

Finally, practitioners should align price promotions with long-term brand positioning goals. Excessive discounting erodes brand equity, especially in the luxury and mid-tier segments. Instead, moderated and

narrative-driven promotions can help maintain premium positioning while still offering financial value, ensuring sustained consumer engagement and loyalty through periods of economic hardship.

Limitations and future research

This study identifies various inherent limitations that could affect the interpretation and generalizability of the results. The geographical focus of the study, particularly within Lebanon's economically challenging context, may limit the generalizability of the results to other regions or markets. While the findings are grounded in Lebanon's crisis context, the identified mechanisms may be transferable to other emerging and volatile markets characterized by prolonged economic uncertainty, though further cross-country validation is warranted. Additionally, basing results on self-reported questionnaire responses is open to biases like social desirability bias and recall bias, which undermine the validity and objectivity of responders. The constraints listed have implications for generalizability and the stability of findings. Future research can transcend these limitations by utilizing longitudinal designs, having larger and more representative samples, or utilizing experimental designs to enhance understanding of causality and dynamic change in consumer behavior over time. Also, further interventions might expand the sampling through varied demographic strata overall (lower to higher income, continuing education, shifted regional location) to better comprehend how promotional stimuli responds for distinct groups of consumers in diverse economic environments. Lastly, future studies should also consider exploring the synergy between price promotions and other elements of the marketing mix (advertising, product innovation, and service). Understanding how each element works together to promote or detract from the ideation of pricing can help brands consider the ultimate pathways to promote and keep brand value and consumer engagement in difficult economic situations, while the traditional marketing mix has been innovated. Additionally, future studies can investigate the influence of advertising endorsers on brand awareness and purchase intention.

Conclusion

This study examined the associations between price promotions, brand image, and consumer purchase decisions within the context of Lebanon's prolonged economic crisis. Using PLS-SEM on data collected from 344 Lebanese consumers, the findings demonstrate that price promotions are positively associated with both brand image and purchase decisions. Furthermore, brand image partially mediates the association between promotions and buying behavior, indicating that promotional effectiveness operates through both economic and symbolic pathways.

These findings challenge conventional assumptions that price promotions necessarily dilute brand equity in distressed markets. Instead, the findings suggest that in hyperinflationary contexts, promotions may function as signals of accessibility and fairness, reinforcing rather than weakening brand perceptions. The study therefore contributes to pricing literature by identifying crisis-driven boundary conditions and by integrating psychological brand mechanisms into models of price-based consumer behavior.

Ethical approval

This study was approved by the Research Ethics Committee (REC) of the Higher Center for Research (HCR) at the Holy Spirit University of Kaslik (USEK) under the reference HCR/EC 2025-043. Written informed consent was obtained from all participants before participation. The study complied with all institutional and national ethical standards for research involving human participants.

Author contributions

CRediT: **Nada Jabbour Al Maalouf**: Conceptualization, Formal analysis, Methodology, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing; **Sibelle Freiha**: Methodology, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing; **Joanna Hanna**: Conceptualization, Methodology, Writing – original draft; **Layal Sfeir**: Methodology, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing; **Chadia Sawaya**: Supervision, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the authors.

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Data availability statement

Data will be made available on reasonable request from the corresponding author (Nada Jabbour Al Maalouf, nada.almaalouf@usek.edu.lb).

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